

In Conversation with Asaithambi, Managing Director, L&W Construction Private Limited

L&W Construction Private Limited is a 100% subsidiary of Lee Kim Tah Woh Hup Pte Ltd (LKTWH) from Singapore. LKTWH in turn is 50:50 joint venture company established by Lee Kim Tah Holdings Ltd and Woh Hup (Pte) Ltd, two of Singapore's oldest construction companies who have successfully completed projects in Singapore, Thailand, Malaysia, Indonesia, Myanmar, Middle East, Sri Lanka and Philippines.

Commencing its Indian operations in Bangalore in 2006, the company's main focus in construction includes but not limited to high-rise residential buildings, townships, commercial buildings, IT Parks, industrial complexes, shopping malls and hotels. A stringent commitment to safety, quality and time has seen the company carve a niche for itself in a remarkably short span of time. Speaking exclusively to The Masterbuilder, M. Asaithambi, Managing Director of the company gave a detailed outline on the company's growth story in India, its key focus areas, the launch of a unique toll free number for its workforce recently as part of May Day celebrations and its future plans. Here are excerpts from the interview.

L &W has made rapid progress in India. Broadly speaking what do you attribute this success to?

Integrity is one thing that we have always been known for in our business. We make sure that within our organization we are very transparent in our approach. Every team member must be provided with fair and transparent is our objective. We also ensure that we are transparent with the sub contractors, suppliers, etc.

Moreover, anyone in our organization can reach me at all times. They can discuss any issue at any level with me. This transparent approach has been a key factor behind our success.

As you may be aware we have executed a 450 acres township for Ascendas. In Chennai we have carried out the entire infrastructure development in the project, including, roads, bridges, etc. After completion of the infrastructure, we have also completed an industrial building for the famous Japanese food flavor company - Ajinomoto. We have done a project for the Ascendas IT Park Chennai Phase 3 Building and Milton Roy, India, facilities in Mahindra City. In Ban-

galore we have successfully completed '27 Park Avenue' a premium residential condominium. We have also completed 4 industrial buildings for Amada, Tyco, TRMN & Shindengen Factory. We have also recently completed a bungalow for RMZ Chairman. We are in the process of handing over 'Globe Tech Park', in Bangalore, which is about a million and half square feet project. We are also executing a project consisting of 425 residential units in Eastpoint.

RMZ ECO World 4A, 4B and 4C IT building, Ascendas Bangalore, MTB3, Netapp and Qualcomm office buildings in Bangalore. Also, Citadines, Ascendas Pune Phase 2 and Ascendas-Hyderabad phase 6. These are some of our recent projects.

When it comes to your team, i.e., your engineers and project managers, do you hire them from India or do you also use your resources from Singapore?

Right now everything is done out of India. We also have people from our Singapore office, basically Indian nationals, those who are interested in relocating here, coming here for our projects. We



left to right: Mr. Ramesh Naik, Labour Inspector, Devanahalli Circle. Mr. Asaithambi Manickam, Managing Director, L&W Construction Private Limited, Mr. Adiga, Addl. Dist. & Session Judge, Bangalore Rural District, Mr. Natraj, Chairman, Taluk Legal Services Committee & Sr. Civil Judge, Devanahalli, Mr. Mallanna, COO & ED, Assetz Property, Mr. Keith Dias, Netapp, Mr. Venugopal, MD, RMZ Corp, Mr. Balaji Aiyar, Country Head, The Maple Tree

do internship / External training for them in Singapore.

Your company has been into construction of residential buildings, as well as turn-key commercial projects. Which one do you feel is the more complicated?

We have been the largest premier residential construction company in Singapore. Similarly, we have also been doing several turnkey projects. If you were to compare, residential projects are tough if delivered like Singapore, since there is more complexity involved. This is because in the case of a residential building, you need to deal with many customers and many options unlike the case of a commercial building or an IT park. There is also more detailing involved in the case of residential buildings.

Are you planning any residential development on your own in India anytime soon?

Yes we have invested 25 Acres land near Devanahalli, Bangalore for our own residential development. First phase of the project is planned to be started early next year. We are also likely to start one in Chennai by mid of next year.

As part of the May Day celebrations recently you have launched a toll free number exclusively for your construction workers. What is this concept all about?

Yes, we have launched an exclusive Toll Free Number – 18004190799 meant for the labourers working on our construction sites as part of May Day celebrations. This is something that I have been thinking of for a long time now. I have spent about six years in India and still feel that there is a gap when it comes to connectivity between the labourers and the management. My goal through this toll free number is to reach out to people, to understand them more closely. The facility is available right now in English, Hindi and Kannada. By calling up the number, the workers can air their grievances, talk about any issue affecting them, get to know about the various schemes, training programs and benefits offered by the company, etc.

We have formed teams, which includes professional counselors which will reach out to people in different camps and tell them how this entire system works. They will take up the interaction

on a personal level with construction workers at different camps. We have 3 camps in Bangalore, 2 camps in Chennai and 1 each in Pune and Hyderabad. We want to educate the construction workers about the various benefits that can enjoy and also ensure their skill development. We have set up induction training rooms specifically for imparting skill development training for the unskilled labour.

This could be a strong USP for your organization.

We insist our sub-vendors, contractors, suppliers, etc also to exercise this in the future. We are not doing this for our company alone. This way we can develop the entire industry. Every construction worker or labourer will get educated this way.

This is innovative thinking. For us basically if we do it, others will also follow suit. It is something that will ultimately benefit the industry. Right now while everybody is complaining about the system that it is not able to produce skilled labourers, while there are some initiatives being taken, not enough is being done on this front. This initiative is our humble contribution towards the betterment of the industry.

As part of this initiative you may need to take care of around 3000 people. With this novel initiative you are trying to turn the unskilled workforce into skilled force. How do you intend going about this challenging process?

Every one of our construction worker is part of our rolls. Everything for them is being done by the company. We genuinely want the construction workers to enjoy the benefits being provided by the company. That is our goal.

We are strongly focused on training on skill development of our construction labour work force. Through this effort we are complementing the strong focus that we have on safety and quality. For us safety is of paramount importance. As mentioned earlier, we do extensive onsite training for this purpose. For us safety is more important in the business. For me first is safety, then quality, the third comes time and the last is cost. This is how we integrate all the key aspects of the business. Anything that is related to safety becomes our first priority.

The realty market here has been going through a tough phase in recent times. Given this scenario what has been your strategy to hold that competitive edge?

Yes, the realty market has been dull for the last couple of years. However, we have got a very decent share of the market. In fact, we have been able to get more quantum of work than what we expected. Our sustained thrust on the quality of deliverables and post maintenance services has been such that our clients are offering us repeat projects.

How many projects do you have in the pipeline?

Currently we have about ₹ 1300 crore worth of projects in hand and this year we will be able to secure another ₹ 1200 crore worth of projects. We don't have an exclusive marketing or business development team. Our work speaks for itself. Our work will get us the next work for us. The customer who works with us today will give us the next job tomorrow. This is how we work. This is our principle and we would like to maintain the same. A good example is available in the form of Ascendas. Today we are working with them for four (Bangalore, Chennai, Pune and Hyderabad) more projects. The focus for us is on long term relationships.

A word about your quality focus.

As mentioned earlier, quality is of paramount importance to us. We are certified ISO 9001:2008 for the quality system, ISO 14001:2004 for environmental and OHSAS 18001:2007 for safety standards by Bureau Veritas.

In countries like Singapore, we see that there are strict codes and rules in place to ensure that there is no dust or pollution arising out of construction sites. Do you adopt similar strategies here?

Yes, we ensure that we minimize pollution to the maximum extent. For example, every vehicle which comes out of our site will be washed before it hits the road in all the practical front.

A lot of new technology has been entering the industry in recent times. What are your views on increased mechanization?

For us we are committed to more

mechanization, rather than be just depend on human labour. This is what we have been insisting from day one and every project. We use more mechanization and technology in our projects. This approach ensures more productivity. Compared to others we use less manpower to build a building.

Has this kind of focus helped you in cutting down on wastage?

Yes, definitely. Recently in our Annual Review Meeting, one of the messages conveyed during it was to cut down on wastage. With wastage it is not only the cost of the material that is being wasted that is a loss, the cost to clear that wastage is also wastage. We are spending almost two times to clear this wastage. For example, last year we did about 1.8 lakh cubic metre of concrete across our business. We so created about 6000 cubic metre wastage. In order to clear this wastage, we spent close to ₹10 crore. It is absolute

wastage of money. Moreover, you will find it difficult to find a dumping place for all the waste generated. So what we have done is to commit that this year we will cut down the wastage by 50%. We should see a substantial improvement happening soon.

A lot of new automation has entered the construction scene with the advent of software systems. Can you tell us briefly about the kind of software that you use?

We have implemented the BIM platform for early clash detection of services coordination, visualization of the actual building, etc, so that we can foresee any of the problems. This is a new concept here. Although industry use similar software, seems to be restriction to implemented 100% in their projects. At the most using it for 3D views and doesn't produce construction drawing from the software. We are putting in all our effort to utilize BIM in the

recent projects and use it to the extent it provides in Construction Drawing, BOQ and Planning. In Singapore moreover, it has become mandatory to use such software systems.

There has been an increase in precast construction in the country. Do you use precast elements in your projects?

Yes, wherever we need we have incorporated precast elements. Good examples are facades, retaining walls, etc, where we have used precast elements in our projects.

There is a lot of emphasis on Green rated projects these days. What about your projects, with respect to the ratings?

Almost all our projects are Green Rated, so clients in various category (Silver, Gold and Platinum) can be confident on us in effective implementation and achievement. ♦